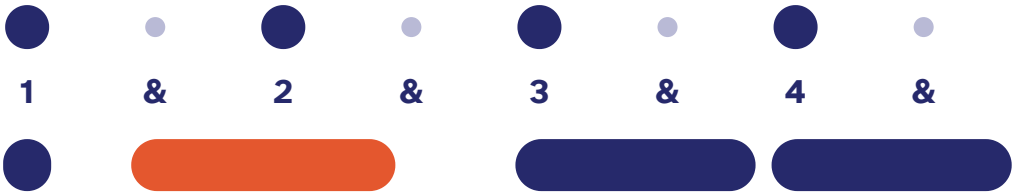
PART II · TIME · 7

Rhythm: off the beat

Now the fun part: rhythm that teases the beat. It only works if the beat underneath stays rock-steady.

THE SECRET

Keep the beat rock-steady and let the rhythm tease it.



starts on “&”, held over beat 2

A note between the beats

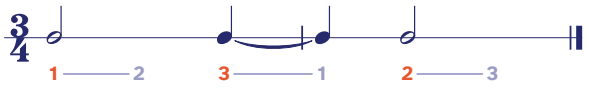
Syncopation



The crotchet starts on “&” and is held through beat 2.

Level 4. Feel beat 2 even though nothing is played on it.

Hemiola



Two bars of 3/4 felt as three minims.

Level 4. Common at cadences in Baroque dances.

Swing Level ½

Common from the first pieces: jazz, blues and many easy modern pieces are marked *swing*. Pairs of quavers are written evenly but played **long–short**, like the first and last notes of a triplet.



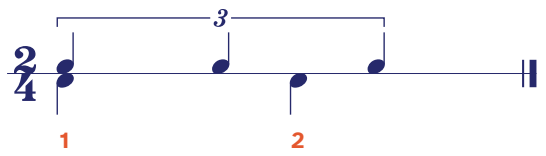
Written



Played

PART II · TIME · 7 · CONTINUED

Polyrhythm Level 7



Three against two: a crotchet triplet above, two crotchets below, starting together.

Rubato Extra

Time is stretched and then given back, for expression: the music leans into a phrase and catches up after it. The pulse always returns. Marked *rubato*, or simply part of the style in much Romantic music.

EXAMPLE 1

Count a syncopation



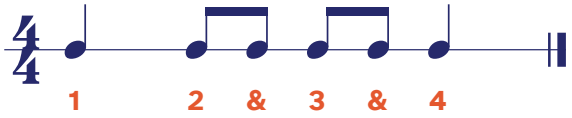
1. **Tap the beats:** 1, 2.
2. **Find the red crotchet:** it starts on the "&", between the beats.
3. **Hold it through beat 2,** then play bar 2 on the beats.

The accent falls **off the beat**: that is syncopation.

EXAMPLE 2

Swing this bar

Swing



1. **Find the quaver pairs:** beats 2 and 3.
2. **Play each pair long-short:** "doo-ba, doo-ba".
3. **Leave the crotchets alone:** beats 1 and 4 stay as written.

Only the **pairs** swing; the beat underneath stays even.

GAME

On the beat or off it?

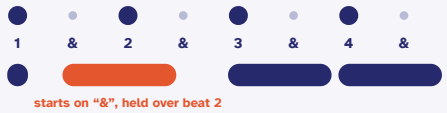
1	2	3	4
starts on 1	starts on &	starts on 2	starts on the & of 3

A note that starts on a number is on the beat; on an "&" it is off the beat. Which are off?

Answer: 2 and 4 are off the beat; 1 and 3 are on it.

PART II · TIME · 7 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

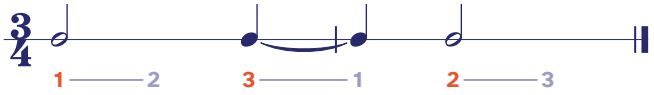


Foot on the beat, hands on the &.

Tap a steady beat with your foot. Clap only between the taps. If the foot starts to follow the hands, slow down.

EXAMPLE 3

Hear a hemiola



1. **Count as written:** "1 2 3, 1 2 3", two bars of 3/4.
2. **Look at the notes:** three minims, each lasting two beats.
3. **Feel the minims** as the beat: the two bars sound like one big bar of three.

The same six beats, felt as **three big ones**: a hemiola.

YOU KNOW THIS

The Entertainer (Scott Joplin)



The high **C** keeps landing just after the beat, not on it: syncopation, the bounce of ragtime.

Try it. Tap the beat with your foot and hum the tune: hear the C slip between the taps.

THINK OF IT Syncopation is a skip in your walk: a step that lands between the beats. Swing is walking with a spring in your step, long-short, long-short. Rubato is borrowing time like pocket money: whatever you spend, you pay back.

TRAP

- × Rushing the short notes after a long one: keep counting inside the long note.
- × Playing a triplet unevenly: three equal notes, not two quick and one long.
- × Letting syncopation drag the pulse: tap the beat with your foot.

SEE ALSO

Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 61 · Words for how to play: Expression (later)

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels ½–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock